Ian Tarter

I study how people make decisions, test what I find against data, and prototype what they need.

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Education

Carnegie Mellon University Master of Human-Computer Interaction (MHCI) — Expected Aug 2027

Carleton College BA, Cognitive Science; minor in Data Science and Statistics — May 2026

- National Merit Scholar; Academic Merit Award, all four years. Coursework: Applied Regression Analysis, HCI, Software Design

Experience

UX Engineer Intern, EXACT Sports Athletic event technology — Summer 2026

- Ran field research at a live combine, observing each station and interviewing coaches to find where time and accuracy were lost.
- Designed and built an iPhone app in Swift that measures athletes with AR and computer vision, writing 200+ of its 233 commits with Claude Code.
- Built camera measurement for six stations, with a manual fallback for all 40, and tested with EXACT staff throughout the build.

Data & Operations Intern, EXACT Sports — Summer 2024

- Built a constraint-based model to assign staff across hundreds of US camps, weighing travel costs, coach availability and university prestige.
- Found the strongest recruiting channels in historical enrollment data; the strategy built on them contributed to a **13%** year-over-year enrollment rise in 2025.
- Coordinated travel and scheduling for **1,000+** coaches, cutting scheduling conflicts.

UX Intern, SayKid Voice-driven learning toys — Summer 2026

- Usability-tested new voice apps for ToyBot, a learning toy children talk to.
- Built voice apps in Voiceflow 4.0, shaping conversations young children can follow.

Research & Development Intern, WizKids Games publisher — Summers 2024, 2025

- Built a Monte Carlo simulation to choose characters for the *Star Trek: Captain's Chair* line, balancing licensing limits against forecast revenue.
- Quantified player preferences with decision-science methods for upcoming releases.
- Evaluated outside game pitches for brand fit and profitability with market analysis and modeled player response.

Research Assistant, Embodied Cognition Lab Carleton College — Winter 2025 – Spring 2026

- Designed study protocols to help international students get comfortable making mistakes while practicing a new language.
- Ran two pilot studies with four participants and led their feedback sessions; wrote proposals for ethics review and reproducibility.

Research Assistant, BIRDS Lab Belonging, Identity, Relationship, Diversity, Science — Fall 2025 – Spring 2026

- Designed mixed-methods protocols measuring how well different forms of allyship support vulnerable groups.
- Developed shared national research methods with professors from Northwestern, UChicago, Yale and Carleton.

Consulting Extern, TAA Services Government consultancy — Winter 2024

- Researched the recruiting market and presented data-backed recommendations to senior leadership.

Founder, Tian Studios Independent game design, tian.studio — Fall 2022 – present

- Designed *The Daily Weather* with Button Shy Games (2026); its Kickstarter raised **$29,000+** from **1,800+** backers.
- Funded and delivered *Rainbow River* on Kickstarter, running production from prototype to manufacturing.
- Designed 40+ tabletop prototypes, tuning mechanics and probability systems from playtest data.

Skills

Research	User interviews, field observation, usability testing, concept testing, surveys, experimental design, qualitative coding, A/B testing
Data	Python (pandas, NumPy), R (tidyverse, ggplot2, Shiny), SQL, regression, hypothesis testing, Monte Carlo simulation
Design & build	Figma, prototyping, Swift and SwiftUI, ARKit, Apple Vision, Voiceflow, Git, LaTeX

Activities

President, Carleton Board Game Club · Secretary, Carleton Model UN · Treasurer, Carleton Birders · Carleton Chamber Choir